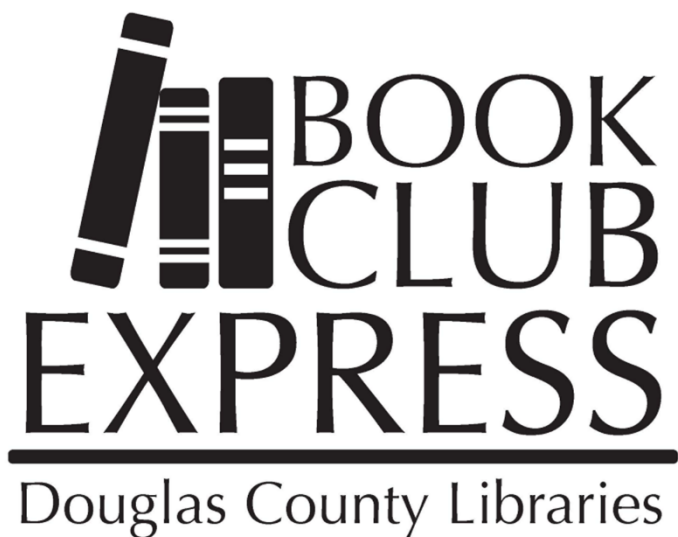




# The Stolen Life of Colette Marceau by Kristin Harmel

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## Discussion Questions

1. Chapter One opens with our main character, Colette --- now in her 80s --- preparing to steal from a neo-Nazi at an upscale benefit in Boston. We're in Colette's perspective, so we can see her justifications for the theft. Did you agree that Colette's actions were justified? Or did you start off with the feeling that she was a criminal, regardless of her motives?
2. In Chapter Two, we meet Colette's mother, Annabel, and we get a bit more insight into why stealing is their family tradition. They believe themselves to be descended from Robin Hood himself. Are there any traditions in your own family --- or things related to your heritage --- that have shaped decisions in your life?
3. Do you believe that being the keeper of a family tradition comes with an obligation to keep that tradition alive? Or do you have the right to chart your own course and leave the past behind?
4. In Chapter Three, we meet Marty, Colette's longtime jewel broker and her dearest friend. Colette strongly believes that her jewel thefts are justified --- and, in fact, she never keeps the profits for herself. But Marty does keep his percentage of the sales. At the same time, though, he's not actually the one doing the stealing. Where do you think Marty falls on the spectrum of right and wrong, especially compared with Colette?
5. Aviva and Colette are essentially family to each other, though they're not related by blood. Do you have someone in your life who you consider family, but who you're not actually related to? If you do, why is this an important relationship to you, and why do you think it's so important for Aviva and Colette?
6. Colette is a young teenager when she meets Tristan in 1942, and we're with her as she begins to fall in love for the first time. Do you remember your first love? Is there anything about your relationship with that person that influenced your future?
7. The Vel' d'Hiv Roundup of July 16, 1942 has been included in many novels, because it was such a momentous turning point in Paris. More than 13,000 Jewish citizens were arrested, including 4,000 children, and many were sent to their deaths. How would you have felt if you were living in Paris in 1942 and woke up to the news of these mass arrests? What would you have done?
8. When Colette, Aviva and Marty visit the 102-year-old Hubert Verdier, who has dementia, at his assisted living facility in Chapter 15, do you think they had the right to push him hard for answers, since they know he had the stolen bracelet in his possession? Or should they have gone easier on him, as Lucas insists?
9. Throughout the chapters set in the past, we see a growing distance between Annabel and her husband, Roger, who disagree sharply about whether she should continue to steal now that there's a war happening. Can you think of a time in your life when a tense situation pushed you

apart from someone you loved? Were you able to resolve things, or did the situation create a permanent divide between the two of you?

10. In Chapter 19, Colette meets Daniel Rosman, who she realizes is the true owner of the bracelets. And yet Colette has held on to her half of the bracelet for decades, because it was the last tangible link she had to her mother and sister. Do you think she's obligated to give it back to him? Why or why not?

11. Daniel tells Colette that his father always said that diamonds never really belong to anyone. "They'll witness births and deaths, war and peace, feast and famine, and yet they'll live on, for millions of years," he says. Is there a piece of jewelry --- or another object --- in your own family that has been passed down through the generations? How do you think that having something special that once belonged to someone else links you to that person?

12. In Chapter 22, the prisoners in Cherche-Midi sing "La Marseillaise," the French national anthem --- and each night at 7:00, they chant, "Notre France vivra," or "Our France will live." These are both drawn from real accounts of life in the prison. Many of these prisoners were waiting to be executed and would never set foot outside the prison again. Why do you think these little forms of resistance mattered so much to them?

13. By the end of the book, we've gotten an overview of Colette's lifetime of theft, spanning from pre-war Paris to 2018 Boston. And we also have a sense of why she has always felt that stealing was necessary. Now that you've finished the book, how do you feel about her actions? Is it okay to do something illegal if you're balancing the scales of justice and if you don't profit personally from the illegal activity? Are the rules for something like this different in wartime than they are in times of peace? In other words, in the end, do you think that the ends justified the means for Colette?

## Author Biography

Harmel is the New York Times bestselling, USA Today bestselling, and #1 international bestselling author of *The Stolen Life of Colette Marceau*, *The Paris Daughter*, *The Book of Lost Names*, *The Winemaker's Wife*, and a dozen other novels that have been translated into more than 35 languages and are sold all over the world. Many of her novels have been optioned for film and television. Her latest, *Meet Me in Paris*, is coming in August 2026. Kristin has been writing professionally since the age of 16, when she began her career as a sportswriter, covering Major League Baseball and NHL hockey for a local magazine in Tampa Bay, Florida. In addition to a long magazine writing career, primarily writing and reporting for PEOPLE magazine (as well as articles published in numerous other magazines, including American Baby, Men's Health, Woman's Day, and more), Kristin was also a frequent contributor to the national television morning show *The Daily Buzz*. Her first novel was published in February 2006. Kristin was born just outside Boston, Massachusetts and spent her childhood there, as well as in Worthington, Ohio, and St. Petersburg, Florida. After graduating with a degree in journalism (with a minor in Spanish) from the University of Florida, she spent time living in Paris and Los Angeles and now lives in Orlando, with her husband and son. A breast cancer survivor, she is also the co-founder and co-host of the popular weekly web show and podcast *Friends & Fiction*.

## Reviews

"A dazzling diamond of a novel.... Kristin Harmel has a rare ability to touch the heart."

— —Hazel Gaynor, New York Times bestselling author of *Before Dorothy*

"Colette's feisty spirit—both as a young girl and later as an older woman reassessing her life and her choices—makes this story joyous and ultimately triumphant. I loved it."

— —Fiona Davis, New York Times bestselling author of *The Stolen Queen*

"A fabulous tale of heartbreak and bravery and just how hard one will fight for those they love. ... Kristin Harmel has done it again."

— —Madeline Martin, New York Times bestselling author of *The Booklover's Library*

"A rousing historical heist novel, but at its core, it's about family, unfaltering love, tragic loss, and the choices—good and bad—that become our legacy."

— —Sarah McCoy, New York Times bestselling author of *Whatever Happened To Lori Lovely*

"This stunning and fastidiously researched story examines the complexity of morality, and the power that ordinary people have to enact change in the world around them. I never wanted to reach the end."

— —Colleen Oakley, USA Today bestselling author of *Jane and Dan at the End of the World*

## **Read-Alikes**

### **As Many Souls as Stars by Natasha Siegel**

For fans of *The Invisible Life of Addie LaRue*, an inventive and romantic speculative novel about two women--a witch and an immortal demon--who make a Faustian bargain and are drawn into a cat-and-mouse chase across multiple lifetimes.

### **Matrix by Lauren Groff**

Cast out of the royal court by Eleanor of Aquitaine, deemed too coarse and rough-hewn for marriage or courtly life, seventeen-year-old Marie de France is sent to England to be the new prioress of an impoverished abbey, its nuns on the brink of starvation and beset by disease. At first taken aback by the severity of her new life, Marie finds focus and love in collective life with her singular and mercurial sisters. In this crucible, Marie steadily supplants her desire for family, for her homeland, for the passions of her youth with something new to her: devotion to her sisters, and a conviction in her own divine visions. Marie, born the last in a long line of women warriors and crusaders, is determined to chart a bold new course for the women she now leads and protects. But in a world that is shifting and corroding in frightening ways, one that can never reconcile itself with her existence, will the sheer force of Marie's vision be bulwark enough? Equally alive to the sacred and the profane, *Matrix* gathers currents of violence, sensuality, and religious ecstasy in a mesmerizing portrait of consuming passion, aberrant faith, and a woman that history moves both through and around. Lauren Groff's new novel, her first since *Fates and Furies*, is a defiant and timely exploration of the raw power of female creativity in a corrupted world.